

JOINT PLANNING PROCESS (JPP) — KNEEBOARD REFERENCE

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STEP 1 — PLANNING INITIATION

Purpose: Establish authority and conditions for planning to begin
Key Inputs: Strategic guidance; WARNORD / PLANORD / EXORD; commander's initial intent
Activities: Receive directive; organize planning team; establish timeline
Outputs: Planning directive; initial timeline; staff roles assigned
⚠ Watch: NOT the same as Mission Analysis — this step receives & organizes; MA analyzes

STEP 2 — MISSION ANALYSIS

Purpose: Understand the problem before developing solutions
Key Inputs: Planning directive; HHQ order; intel products; staff estimates
Activities: Analyze mission; ID specified/implied/essential tasks; assess OE; develop CCIRs
Outputs: Mission statement; commander's intent; planning guidance; CCIRs; staff estimates
⚠ Watch: MA defines the PROBLEM — COAs are not developed here

STEP 3 — COA DEVELOPMENT

Purpose: Develop multiple feasible solutions that satisfy commander's intent
Key Inputs: Mission statement; commander's intent; planning guidance; staff estimates
Activities: Develop COA concepts; screen against five criteria; prepare COA briefs
Outputs: Two or more viable COAs ready for analysis
⚠ Watch: 5 Criteria: Valid · Feasible · Acceptable · Distinguishable · Complete

STEP 4 — COA ANALYSIS (WARGAMING)

Purpose: Stress-test each COA against adversary actions to ID risks & decision points
Key Inputs: Developed COAs; intel assessments; staff estimates; evaluation criteria
Activities: Wargame each COA vs. most likely & most dangerous enemy COAs; record results
Outputs: Wargaming results; refined COAs; identified risks; decision points
⚠ Watch: Analysis TESTS options — it does NOT select them (that's Step 5)

SEVEN JOINT FUNCTIONS

C2: The means by which a commander guides and directs forces to accomplish the mission.
Information: The integration of information-related capabilities to influence audiences and protect friendly data.
Intelligence: The collection and analysis of information about the adversary and the operational environment.
Fires: The use of weapon systems and other capabilities to create specific lethal or nonlethal effects on a target.
Movement & Maneuver: The positioning of forces and combat power to gain an advantage over the enemy.
Protection: The preservation of the force's effectiveness through safety, security, and health measures.
Sustainment: The provision of logistics, personnel services, and operational support needed to maintain operations.

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JPP STEPS 5-7 | KEY REVIEWS | J-STAFF QUICK REF

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STEP 5 — COA COMPARISON

Purpose: Evaluate analyzed COAs against criteria; produce staff recommendation
Key Inputs: Wargaming results; refined COAs; evaluation criteria
Activities: Apply evaluation criteria; use decision matrix; develop staff recommendation
Outputs: Staff recommendation; COA comparison briefing
⚠ Watch: Staff RECOMMENDS — Commander DECIDES (Step 6)

STEP 6 — COA APPROVAL

Purpose: Commander selects COA and provides refined planning guidance
Key Inputs: COA comparison results; staff recommendation; wargaming results
Activities: COA decision briefing; commander decision; capture refined guidance
Outputs: Commander-approved COA; refined planning guidance for plan development
⚠ Watch: Approval is a TRANSITION point — planning continues into Step 7

STEP 7 — PLAN DEVELOPMENT

Purpose: Convert approved COA into an executable plan or order
Key Inputs: Approved COA; refined guidance; wargaming results; staff estimates
Activities: Develop base plan/order; write functional annexes; coordinate across staff
Outputs: OPLAN / OPORD / CONPLAN with all required annexes
⚠ Watch: Requires continuous cross-staff coordination — not just writing

▲ TARGETED REVIEW PRIORITIES (Before Resident Course)

- **Planning Initiation vs. Mission Analysis:** Initiation = receive & organize; MA = analyze the problem
- **COA Analysis vs. COA Comparison:** Analysis = test each COA; Comparison = rank COAs against each other
- **COA Approval vs. Plan Development:** Approval = commander decides; Plan Dev = turn decision into executable order
- **Feasibility vs. Acceptability:** Feasible = can we resource it? Acceptable = is the cost/risk worth it?
- **Specified vs. Implied Tasks:** Specified = written in the order; Implied = must happen but not stated
- **OPLAN vs. OPORD vs. CONPLAN:** Know what drives selection of each plan format
- **J-Dir Role:** Review how your role shapes feasible COAs — engage early in every step. Look to what annexes you are responsible for and which you support

J-STAFF QUICK REFERENCE

J-1	Personnel	J-2	Intelligence
J-3	Operations	J-4	Logistics
J-5	Plans	J-6	Comms & Cyber

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